Does RTI work? First-cut tables and figures

Amar and Sood

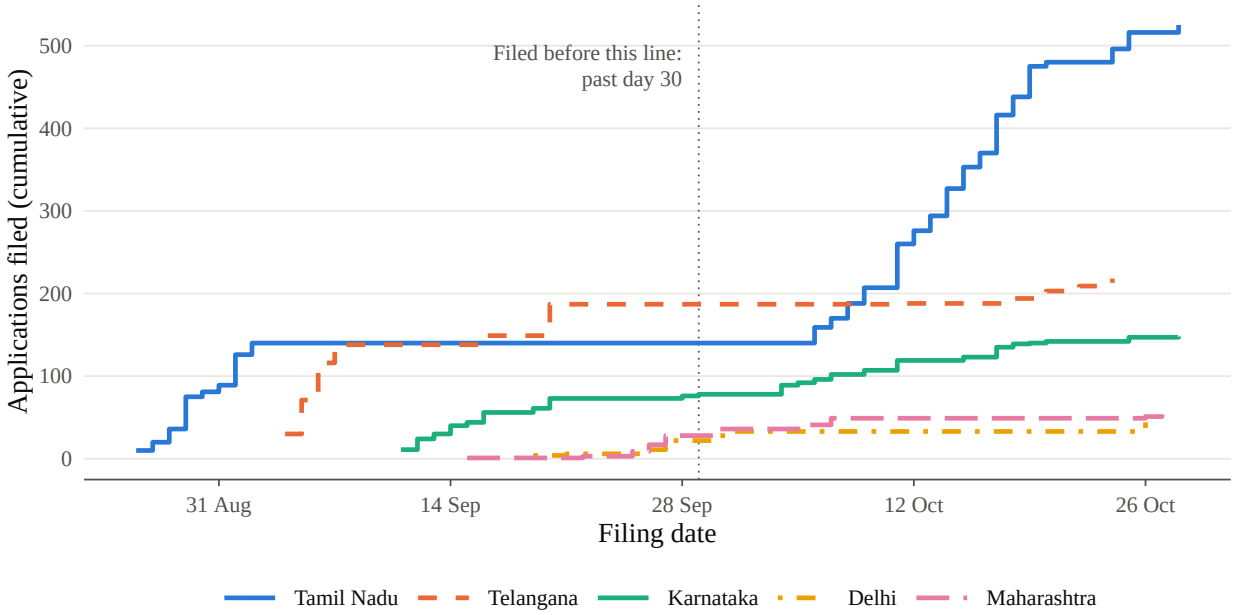
Data as of 29 October 2026

Table 1: Sample and filing by state

State	Frame	Drawn	Plain / legal	Filed	Filed (%)	Past day 30	Filing window
Tamil Nadu	17,417	1,000	700 / 300	525	52.5	140	26 Aug to 28 Oct
Telangana	3,401	375	262 / 113	218	58.1	187	04 Sep to 24 Oct
Karnataka	1,800	180	126 / 54	148	82.2	78	11 Sep to 28 Oct
Delhi	223	44	30 / 14	44	100.0	22	19 Sep to 26 Oct
Maharashtra	328	66	46 / 20	61	92.4	28	15 Sep to 27 Oct
All	23,169	1,665	1,164 / 501	996	59.8	455	26 Aug to 28 Oct

Notes: Data as of 29 October 2026. Past day 30: filed by 29 September, so the 30-day limit in s.7(1) has passed. Tamil Nadu is drawn by department × tier quotas, other states proportionally to department group with a cap.

Figure 1: Cumulative filings by state



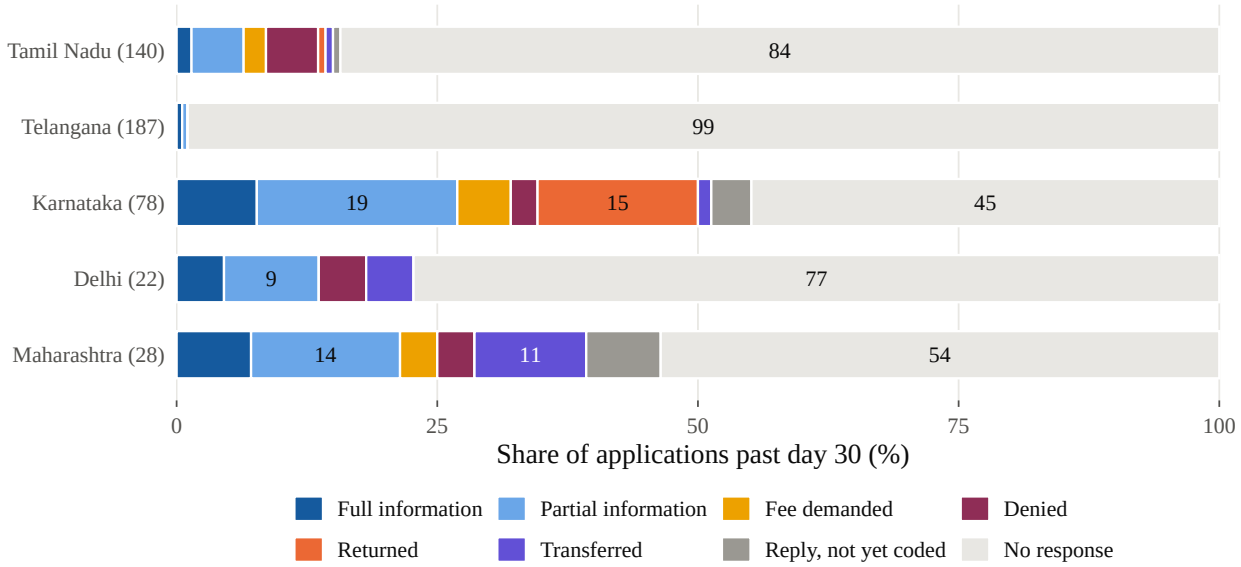
Notes: One line per state; 996 applications have a filing date, from the portal acknowledgment where one exists, otherwise the RA sheet. Applications filed before the dotted line have passed the 30-day limit in s.7(1).

Table 2: Response within 30 days of filing, by state (%)

State	N	Any response	95% CI	Reply	Information supplied
Tamil Nadu	140	12.9	[8.3, 19.4]	12.1	5.0
weighted to frame		7.0	[2.6, 11.4]	6.9	2.1
Telangana	187	1.1	[0.3, 3.8]	1.1	1.1
Karnataka	78	52.6	[41.6, 63.3]	51.3	26.9
Delhi	22	22.7	[10.1, 43.4]	18.2	13.6
Maharashtra	28	46.4	[29.5, 64.2]	35.7	21.4
All states	455	17.4	[14.2, 21.1]	16.0	8.6
All excl. Telangana	268	28.7	[23.6, 34.4]	26.5	13.8

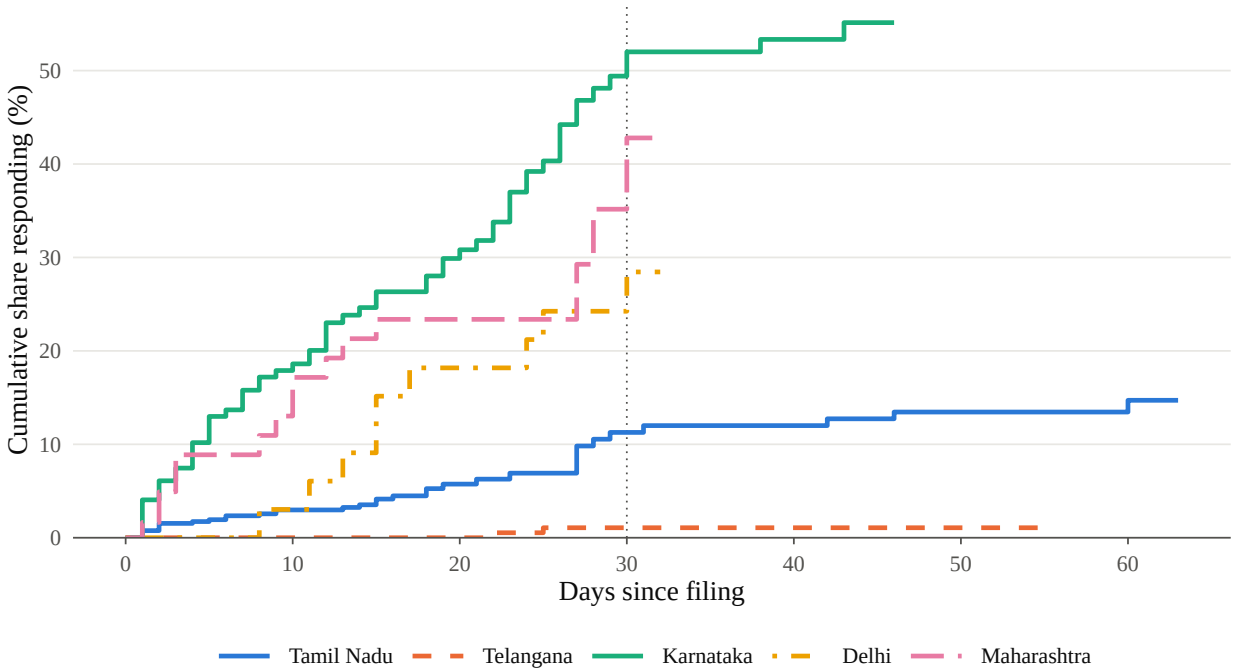
Notes: Applications past day 30. Any response: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Reply: excludes transfers. Information supplied: reply coded full or partial, a lower bound. Telangana is a lower bound because its portal sends no status emails. Brackets: Wilson 95% intervals.

Figure 2: What has come back so far, by state



Notes: Applications past day 30, status as of 29 October, whenever the reply came. N in parentheses; segments of 8% or more are labeled. Reply documents double-coded blind, with disagreements adjudicated. Telangana is a lower bound because its portal sends no status emails.

Figure 3: Time to first response, by state



Notes: Kaplan-Meier estimates of time to any response (any office action, including a transfer or fee demand), all 996 dated filings, censored at 29 October; curves stop when fewer than 10 applications remain at risk. Dotted line: the 30-day limit in s.7(1). Telangana is a lower bound because its portal sends no status emails.

Table 3: How fast offices respond

	Days since filing					Responders:
State	7	14	21	30	45	median days / N
Panel A. Any response by this day (%)						
Tamil Nadu	2.5	3.4	6.4	12.9	14.3	15
Telangana	0.0	0.0	0.0	1.1	0.0	24
Karnataka	15.5	24.4	32.4	52.6	55.0	12
Delhi	0.0	9.1	18.2	22.7		15
Maharashtra	10.2	22.4	24.5	46.4		11
All excl. Telangana	5.5	10.0	16.9	28.7	23.3	13
Panel B. Applications exposed at least this long (N)						
Tamil Nadu	480	353	188	140	140	35
Telangana	209	188	187	187	138	2
Karnataka	142	123	102	78	40	62
Delhi	33	33	33	22	0	9
Maharashtra	49	49	49	28	0	18
All excl. Telangana	704	558	372	268	180	124

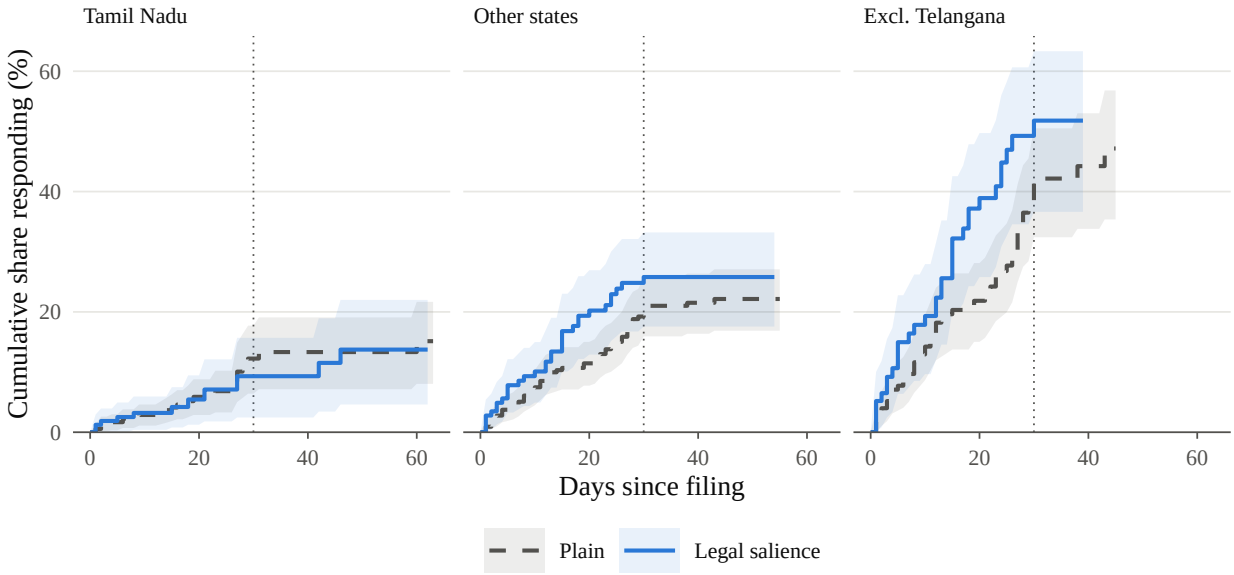
Notes: All dated filings; each column uses only applications filed at least that long ago, so shares need not rise. Any response: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Blank: fewer than 10 applications. Last column: median days (Panel A), responders (Panel B).

Table 4: Any response within 30 days, by letter (raw comparison)

	Plain		Legal salience			
State	N	%	N	%	Difference	Fisher p
Tamil Nadu	93	12.9	47	12.8	−0.1	1.000
Telangana	130	1.5	57	0.0	−1.5	1.000
Karnataka	52	48.1	26	61.5	13.5	0.338
Delhi	15	20.0	7	28.6	8.6	1.000
Maharashtra	20	45.0	8	50.0	5.0	1.000
All states	310	16.5	145	19.3	2.9	0.507
All excl. Telangana	180	27.2	88	31.8	4.6	0.473

Notes: Applications past day 30. Legal salience: the letter adds the s.7(1) deadline and s.20 penalties to the plain request. Any response: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Raw differences in percentage points; the Tamil Nadu row is confounded with tier. Interim, unregistered look.

Figure 4: Time to first response, by letter



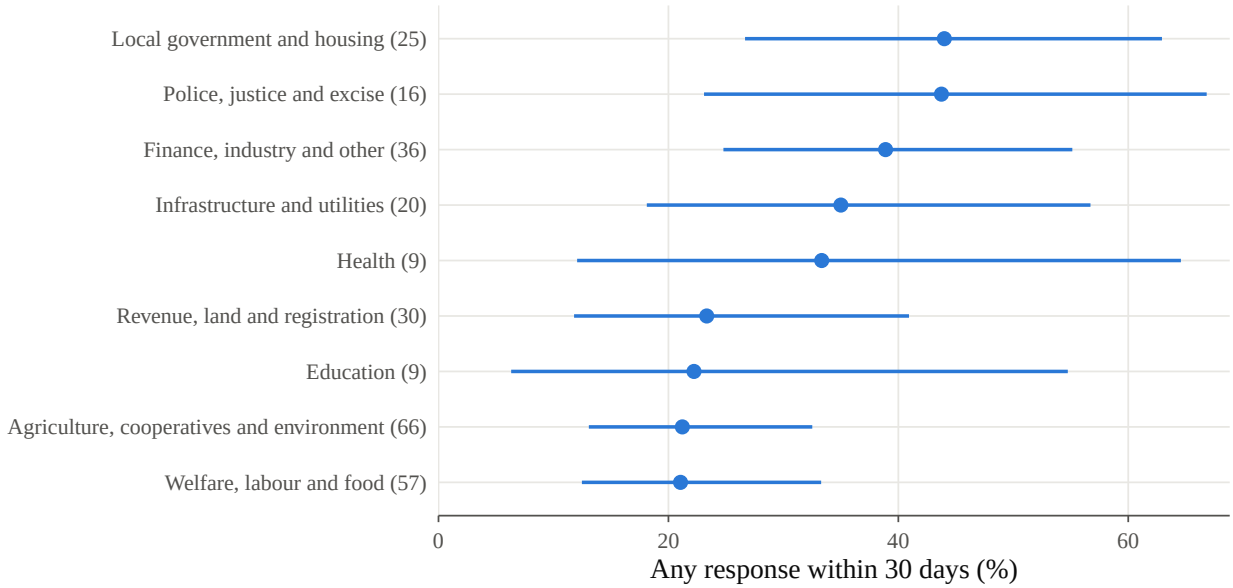
Notes: Kaplan-Meier estimates of time to any response (any office action, including a transfer or fee demand) with 95% bands, all filings, raw, so the Tamil Nadu panel is confounded with tier. Legal salience: the letter adds the s.7(1) deadline and s.20 penalties. Excl. Telangana: Karnataka, Delhi and Maharashtra. Dotted line: day 30.

Table 5: Response by Tamil Nadu tier and by filing cohort (%)

Group	N	Any response	Reply	Information supplied
Panel A. Tamil Nadu by tier, by day 30				
Department	7	28.6	28.6	28.6
Head of Department	21	42.9	38.1	14.3
Sub Office	112	6.2	6.2	1.8
Panel B. By filing cohort, by day 14				
Tamil Nadu, filed by 30 September	140	5.0	4.3	2.1
Tamil Nadu, filed in October	213	2.3	0.5	0.0
Telangana, filed by 30 September	187	0.0	0.0	0.0
Telangana, filed in October	1			
Karnataka, filed by 30 September	78	23.1	21.8	9.0
Karnataka, filed in October	45	26.7	24.4	6.7
Delhi, filed by 30 September	28	10.7	10.7	10.7
Delhi, filed in October	5			
Maharashtra, filed by 30 September	36	25.0	16.7	11.1
Maharashtra, filed in October	13	15.4	15.4	15.4

Notes: Any response: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Reply: excludes transfers. Information supplied: coded full or partial. Panel A: past day 30, from only 11 of 40 departments because of filing order. Panel B: filed at least 14 days ago; blank cells have fewer than 10 applications.

Figure 5: Any response within 30 days, by government function



Notes: Applications past day 30, excluding Telangana. N in parentheses; bars are Wilson 95% intervals. Any response: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Function is keyword-coded from department and office names (crosswalk in data/cleaned/). Pooled across states, so state differences are not removed.

Table 6: Any response within 30 days, by filer group

	RA1 and RA3		RA2 and RA4		Within block	
State	N	%	N	%	Difference	(SE)
Tamil Nadu	75	10.7	65	15.4	−3.8	(5.3)
Telangana	124	1.6	63	0.0	−1.6	(1.1)
Karnataka	28	57.1	50	50.0	−7.1	(11.9)
Delhi	11	27.3	11	18.2	−9.1	(18.6)
Maharashtra	12	33.3	16	56.2	22.9	(19.1)
All states	250	13.2	205	22.4	−2.0	(3.1)
All excl. Telangana	126	24.6	142	32.4	−2.2	(5.3)

Notes: Applications past day 30. Any response: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Only RA2 and RA4 could receive calls and both are one person, so this bundles phone with name and address. Difference: coefficient on RA2/RA4 with block fixed effects and robust SE, in percentage points.

Table 7: What the coded replies contain

	Tamil Nadu (26)	Others (78)	All (104)	All (%)
Disposition				
Full information	2	14	16	15
Partial information	8	30	38	37
Fee asked first	3	8	11	11
Denied or deflected	8	6	14	13
Returned	1	14	15	14
Transferred	4	6	10	10
Data supplied				
Application-level register	2	25	27	26
Monthly or category counts	1	6	7	7
Period totals	6	14	20	19
Prose only	1	0	1	1
None	16	33	49	47
Section 25 annual return				
Supplied	4	19	23	22
Not held	3	3	6	6
Offered on payment	5	7	12	12
Told to apply separately	0	2	2	2
Referred to website	2	1	3	3
Not addressed	12	46	58	56
How it arrived				
Post	17	34	51	49
Portal	7	26	33	32
Email	2	18	20	19
Provisions cited				
Exemption, s.8	0	3	3	3
Sections 2(f) or 7(9)	7	5	12	12
Transfer, s.6(3)	0	6	6	6
None	18	63	81	78

Notes: All 104 coded replies, whenever they came. Double-coded blind, with disagreements adjudicated. Fees were quoted in 16 replies (median Rs 37, maximum Rs 832).

Table 8: Office phone calls to the filer, RA2 and RA4 filings only

State	Filings	Calls	Per 100 filings	Calls / filings	
				Plain	Legal
Panel A. By state					
Tamil Nadu	267	2	0.7	1 / 185	1 / 82
Telangana	94	0	0.0	0 / 65	0 / 29
Karnataka	86	1	1.2	1 / 60	0 / 26
Delhi	22	1	4.5	1 / 16	0 / 6
Maharashtra	32	5	15.6	5 / 22	0 / 10
All	501	9	1.8	8 / 348	1 / 153
Panel B. Why the office called					
Clarify what is sought		3			
Ask why the filer applied		3			
Give an answer by phone		2			
Confirm a reply arrived		1			

Notes: Only RA2 and RA4 could receive calls, so other filings are excluded and calls never enter response rates. Taken from RA notes up to 29 October, so possibly undercounted. The Act requires no reason from the applicant (s.6(2)).

Table 9: Does the letter predict who is filed and who has reached day 30?

State	N	Filed (%)			Past day 30 (%)		
		Plain	Legal	*p*	Plain	Legal	*p*
Panel A. All drawn applications							
Tamil Nadu	1,000	52.0	53.7	0.867	13.3	15.7	0.901
Telangana	375	57.6	59.3	0.702	49.6	50.4	0.774
Karnataka	180	81.7	83.3	0.797	41.3	48.1	0.399
Delhi	44	100.0	100.0		50.0	50.0	
Maharashtra	66	93.5	90.0	0.641	43.5	40.0	0.641

Panel B. Tamil Nadu past day 30, by tier					
	N	Plain	Legal	Legal (%)	Drawn (%)
Department	7	0	7	100.0	32.5
Head of Department	21	15	6	28.6	25.7
Sub Office	112	78	34	30.4	30.6

Notes: Past day 30: filed by 29 September. Panel A: *p*-values on the letter in a linear probability model with randomization-block fixed effects and robust SEs. Panel B: counts, with the legal share among them and among all drawn in that tier. All 7 department-tier filings past day 30 got the legal letter.

Table 10: Effect of the legal-salience letter

	Tamil Nadu		Other states		Excl. Telangana	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Panel A. Any response by day 30						
Legal letter	−0.1	1.1	3.6	7.4	10.9	32.8
	(6.0)	(5.8)	(3.9)	(3.8)	(9.3)	(13.4)
Plain-letter mean	12.9	9.1	18.0	12.0	42.5	39.1
Detectable effect (2.8 × SE)	16.9	16.2	10.9	10.8	26.1	37.6
Randomization-inference p		1.000	0.448	0.152	0.261	0.070
N	140	128	315	242	128	73
Panel B. Reply by day 30						
Legal letter	0.9	1.1	2.9	6.6	9.1	29.8
	(6.0)	(5.8)	(3.9)	(3.7)	(9.3)	(13.0)
Plain-letter mean	11.8	9.1	16.6	11.4	39.1	37.0
Detectable effect (2.8 × SE)	16.7	16.2	10.8	10.3	26.0	36.4
Randomization-inference p		1.000	0.550	0.172	0.322	0.126
N	140	128	315	242	128	73
Panel C. Information supplied by day 30						
Legal letter	2.1	−1.1	−3.4	−0.5	−6.0	2.0
	(4.2)	(3.5)	(3.3)	(3.0)	(7.8)	(11.3)
Plain-letter mean	4.3	3.4	11.1	7.8	25.3	23.9
Detectable effect (2.8 × SE)	11.7	9.8	9.1	8.3	21.9	31.6
Randomization-inference p		1.000	0.387	1.000	0.524	1.000
N	140	128	315	242	128	73
Randomization-block FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Department-group FE	No	No	No	Yes	No	Yes

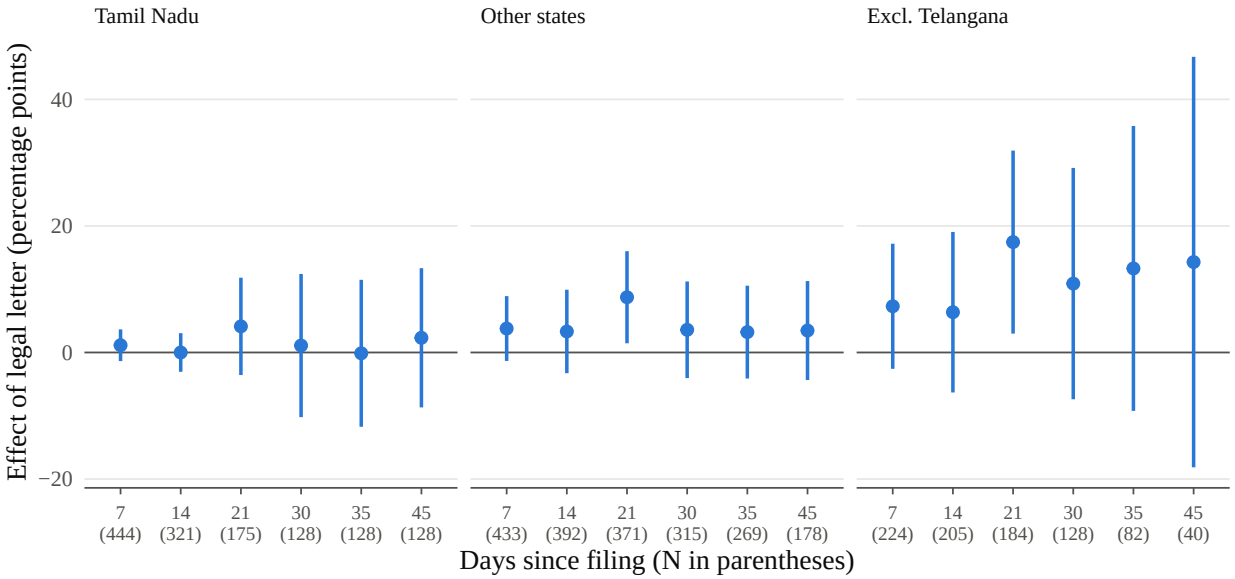
Notes: Linear probability models, applications past day 30, percentage points, robust SEs. Legal letter: cites the s.7(1) deadline and s.20 penalties. Any response includes transfers and fee demands; reply excludes them; information: coded full or partial. Blocks: department × tier (Tamil Nadu), state × batch (others). Columns (4), (6) rest on 162, 41 applications in department groups with both letters.

Table 11: Legal-salience letter: alternative specifications

	Tamil Nadu		Other states		Excl. Telangana	
	Coef. (SE)	N	Coef. (SE)	N	Coef. (SE)	N
Linear probability, any response (percentage points)						
Baseline, by day 30	1.1 (5.8)	128	3.6 (3.9)	315	10.9 (9.3)	128
By day 35	−0.1 (5.9)	128	3.2 (3.7)	269	13.3 (11.5)	82
By day 45	2.3 (5.6)	128	3.5 (4.0)	178	14.3 (16.5)	40
By day 14, all exposed that long	0.0 (1.6)	321	3.3 (3.4)	392	6.4 (6.5)	205
Without low-confidence email matches	1.1 (5.8)	128	3.6 (3.9)	315	10.9 (9.3)	128
Adding RA fixed effects	1.2 (5.8)	128	3.7 (3.9)	315	11.1 (9.4)	128
Adding filing-week fixed effects	1.3 (5.8)	128	4.0 (3.9)	315	13.4 (9.3)	128
Excluding Maharashtra (shorter letter)			3.5 (3.8)	287	12.4 (10.4)	100
RA2 and RA4 filings only	4.3 (8.6)	57	−1.2 (6.6)	140	−2.3 (12.4)	77
RA1 and RA3 filings only	3.1 (8.0)	65	6.4 (4.7)	175	26.2 (14.6)	51
Cox model, all filings (hazard ratio)						
Legal letter, stratified by block	1.16 (0.49)	525	1.41 (0.31)	471	1.46 (0.33)	253

Notes: All rows: any response (any office action, including a transfer or fee demand), legal letter as in Table 10, block fixed effects, robust SEs. Later cutoffs and the day-14 row use applications exposed that long. Filer-group rows are exploratory. The Cox model is our addition, not in the design document; its SE is on the hazard-ratio scale.

Figure 6: Effect of the legal-salience letter by days since filing



Notes: Each point is a separate linear probability model of any response (any office action, including a transfer or fee demand) by that day on the legal letter, with randomization-block fixed effects, on applications filed at least that long ago. Bars are 95% intervals from robust SEs. The sample changes across horizons.

Table 12: Correlates of any response within 30 days (descriptive)

	All excl. Telangana	Tamil Nadu	Karnataka, Delhi, Maharashtra
State (relative to Tamil Nadu)			
Karnataka	45.7 (7.3)		
Delhi	10.5 (12.5)		
Maharashtra	39.1 (9.9)		
Tamil Nadu tier (relative to Sub Office)			
Department		26.7 (17.4)	
Head of Department		38.0 (11.0)	
Function (relative to finance, industry and other)			
Agriculture, cooperatives and environment	−10.4 (8.5)	5.5 (8.9)	−26.9 (19.2)
Education	−31.5 (17.8)		−44.5 (19.8)
Health	−2.0 (18.0)	13.8 (16.0)	−16.1 (26.6)
Infrastructure and utilities	−3.0 (11.1)	9.1 (11.2)	−3.6 (19.3)
Local government and housing	−26.9 (13.2)		−45.1 (16.0)
Police, justice and excise	−10.6 (13.5)		−26.7 (14.9)
Revenue, land and registration	−16.5 (9.8)	3.8 (9.7)	−35.9 (19.3)
Welfare, labour and food	−24.9 (8.8)	−5.8 (9.5)	−47.3 (15.1)
Application			
Filed by RA2 or RA4	3.6 (5.1)	3.4 (5.3)	4.1 (8.9)
Legal letter	6.8 (5.4)	−2.4 (6.1)	16.4 (9.5)
State × batch FE	No	No	Yes
N	268	140	128

Notes: Linear probability models, applications past day 30, percentage points, robust SEs in parentheses. Outcome: any office action, including a transfer or fee demand. Telangana is excluded because its outcome is not comparable. Only the letter and, within state, the filer are randomized; the rest are associations. Blank function cells: no such offices past day 30.

Table 13: What the original inputs cover

State	Drawn	Filed	Portal ack.	Receipt	Reply PDF	Notice, no PDF
Tamil Nadu	1,000	525	367	525	27	4
Telangana	375	218	121	216	2	0
Karnataka	180	148	148	144	51	10
Delhi	44	44	0	39	9	0
Maharashtra	66	61	60	59	16	0
All	1,665	996	696	983	105	14

Notes: Filed: a real registration number on the RA sheet or a portal acknowledgment. Notice, no PDF: the portal says disposed, returned or rejected, but the reply has not been downloaded. No status notices reached the inboxes from Telangana, Delhi or Maharashtra, so replies left only on those portals are not observed.

Table 14: Rebuilt from the original inputs, against the email tracker

Field	Agree	Differ
Filed	1,661	4
Filing date	1,660	5
Acknowledgment date	1,665	0
Transfer date	1,665	0
Fee demand date	1,665	0
Disposed date	1,664	1
Returned date	1,664	1
Rejected date	1,665	0
Office email date	1,662	3
First response date	1,663	2

Notes: Applications drawn, field by field. The 4 filed differences are number cells saying no number was issued, and the filing-date differences are all on unfiled applications. The rest are notices dated the data date, and messages matched by hand after reading them.

Table 15: Response within 30 days: first cut against the rebuild (%)

	Any response		Reply		Information supplied	
State	First cut	Rebuild	First cut	Rebuild	First cut	Rebuild
Tamil Nadu	12.9	12.9	11.4	12.1	4.3	5.0
Telangana	1.1	1.1	1.1	1.1	1.1	1.1
Karnataka	51.3	52.6	50.0	51.3	25.6	26.9
Delhi	22.7	22.7	13.6	18.2	9.1	13.6
Maharashtra	46.4	46.4	32.1	35.7	17.9	21.4
Tamil Nadu, weighted to frame	7.0	7.0	6.0	6.9	2.0	2.1
All states	17.1	17.4	15.2	16.0	7.7	8.6
All excl. Telangana	28.4	28.7	25.0	26.5	12.3	13.8

Notes: First cut: tracker outputs and first-pass reply coding. Rebuild: original inputs and adjudicated coding. Any response moves only through corrected reply dates; information supplied also moves through adjudicated dispositions.

Table 16: Reply coding: agreement between two independent coders

	N	Agree (%)	Kappa
Panel A. Agreement			
Information supplied, yes or no	104	92.3	0.85
Disposition	104	74.0	0.69
Data format	104	87.5	0.81
Section 25 return	104	90.4	0.84
Reply date	104	85.6	0.85
		First pass	Adjudicated
Panel B. Disposition counts			
Full information		27	16
Partial information		20	38
Fee asked first		18	11
Denied or deflected		10	14
Returned		16	15
Transferred		13	10

Notes: Panel A: the second coder could not see the first codes. Panel B: disagreements went to an adjudicator who could not tell the coders apart. Full now requires the Section 25 return to be answered as well, which is stricter than the first pass. Reply coding cannot be rerun, only audited.